



» CHAMPIONS TROPHY DIARY

Marquee game: In Lahore's bustling streets, cricket fans huddle around a roadside shop, eyes fixed on the screen, as Pakistan takes on India in the ICC Champions Trophy showdown. AP

Beyond boundaries: Cricket, music and memories on the road

Our correspondents capture Pakistan's **warm hospitality, cricket fandom, and cultural bonds** with India during the ICC Champions Trophy, while also highlighting the muted buzz in Dubai due to the hybrid tournament model.

“A *ap pehle kabhi aaye ho idhar?* (Have you been here before?)” asked the immigration officer, examining the documents. She smiled upon learning that this was the Diary’s first visit to Pakistan. “Welcome to the

country. May you have a great tournament,” she said.

Pakistan last hosted a global event in 1996, when the Diary was in junior school. Nearly 30 years later, covering the ICC Champions Trophy in Pakistan felt surreal. After a whirlwind journey from Mumbai to Delhi to Amritsar in a single day, the

Diary arrived at the Wagah-Attari Border, ready to cross on foot.

But heavy rain posed a challenge — keeping the documents dry. With the help of porters, the luggage was managed, and after final security checks on the Indian side, the Diary stepped into Pakistan.

“Aaj sardi bahot hai (It’s very cold